gentle but firm education in the arts of political persuasion. We always felt change was possible.

I exhibited my share of cruelty, too. It was a Tom Sawyer kind of childhood in many ways, with long days spent outdoors, learning how to master the environment and conquer danger. I was fond of my magnifying glass and would march through the bush with it. The cruelty was a matter between me and the sugar ants, which trooped across the ground and often found themselves sizzled under my lens. The ants would climb up your trousers and bite you. Worse were the green tree ants, common in Australia among the forests and low-lying places. Not only did they bite, they sprayed a burning fluid from their abdomen onto the wound. There were so many species of ant and none was immune, so far as my infant mind was concerned, from the power of my spying glass. It seemed natural to enhance the power of the sun to punish hostility. The war between five-year-old boys and ants is legendary.

There were others sorts of hostility, too. My parents travelled with a small fold-up theatre – they did shows, little theatricals, later involving puppets – and I suppose they were bohemians. They were against the war and had demonstrated; they'd been in and out of the cities. They were worldly in a way that wasn't always typical in Queensland, especially among the non-hippy community. My mother had modelled and acted, and together they designed sets and read books. To some people it was no kind of life to live, and I suppose that was my introduction to prejudice. We came back to Magnetic Island one time and got a house up in the hills. The atmosphere was clammy and the heat would make people lethargic; atmosphere is important in Australia, and in many places, creating not only a physical state in people but a mental state as well, and when I think of that house on the island I think of a certain constriction in people that borrows from the weather. Some of our neighbours were constricted in that way, perhaps especially in reaction to my parents' notions of freedom.

My parents had a gun to deal with snakes. There were snakes in the bath from time to time. One day we came back up the hill to discover the house was on fire. About twenty local people were standing around as the flames licked around the veranda. No one was attempting to put out the fire and suddenly all this ammunition in the house exploded. I remember one of the neighbours laughing and saying we couldn't stand the heat. It was all very sinister, and the fire brigade took forty minutes to come. In many ways that